

CREATING JAZZ BASS LINES

by
JIM STINNETT



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Introduction

Playing jazz requires two general capabilities: the ability to physically play your instrument and the knowledge of what to play. This book will deal with what to play on the bass in a jazz setting.

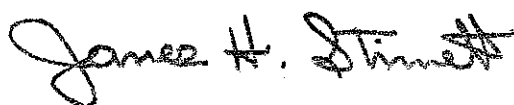
In jazz, the most valuable asset a musician can have is *a well developed ear*. When improvising, a good ear is quicker and more sensitive than any thought process. A player with a really good ear can play totally by reflex, reacting to his musical surroundings with spontaneous quickness. Listening to the great players, either in a live setting or on recordings, is the first step in developing your ear. After much listening you will become familiar with the sounds which are the basic "language of jazz".

With the abundance of books and materials available to the student today it is easy to overlook the importance of developing a good ear. Often one simply reads through a book and wonders why it was so simple. The answer might be it was simple for you to physically execute, but could you have heard and conceived these ideas on your own? The aim of this book is to develop a concept of how to create jazz bass lines and get these ideas in your ears. I urge you to memorize all the material in this book and transpose, by ear, to all keys. When you have learned a musical line or phrase so well that it seems second nature, then and only then will it sound natural in your playing.

Learning what to play is exactly the same as learning what to say when you speak. By learning new words we increase our vocabulary and ultimately our ability to communicate. Most of us have a far greater reading vocabulary than speaking vocabulary. In music all communication is spoken. Keep in mind that music is an aural art form.

The simplest, and most effective way of ear training is to play along with recordings. Using your instrument will develop *ear-hand coordination*. This is the goal. The major problem to overcome in the beginning is inhibition. No one wants to sound bad, so many people cheat by using the written music or only playing along with songs they already know. You must practice playing in situations where you do not know what is coming next. This is *improvisation*. The purpose of this type of practice is to learn to let your ear tell your hands what to do. After much practice at playing with recordings you will be surprised at how often you will play things which sound good to you even though you may not know what they are. This is called playing "playing by ear". All of the great players play by ear even though they may have an extensive knowledge of jazz theory.

So now you may be wondering, "Why should I study jazz from a book if I want to play by ear?" The sounds of jazz are so unique and varied that you may not be able to recognize any distinguishable patterns. Most of us need to guide and expose our ears to the sounds which we know by study to be good. For this reason you need exposure to sounds on a very elementary level. It is important that each new idea be translated into sounds and thoroughly mastered by the ear before moving on to the next sound. When this approach is followed you will feel confident in your playing. It is like building levels of a foundation. Each level needs to be solid before putting a new one on top. Sometimes we forget things we have learned. But if you are patient and thorough I guarantee that your ear will not forget the sounds you learn.



J.H. Stinnett

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Cover Illustration by Paul Metcalf
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Time

Most of the music in our world moves in time. With some music this movement is quite subtle. While with other styles the beat may be heard with varying degrees of emphasis. When listening to music with a continuous pulse the “time” is a very important factor. In jazz the “time” is the thing. By using the word “time” to define a feeling instead of a measurable amount of duration, this concept of time in music can become confusing.

When a jazz musician talks about *time* he is not speaking of tempo or velocity. Rather he is speaking of intensity and consistency. When a musician is playing good time he is “grooving”. The word *groove* itself implies an even steadiness. “He’s in the groove” is a common phrase used to describe someone whose playing is smooth and steady. When a jazz group is playing good time it is common to say that they are “cooking”. This implies an energy or intensity like heat boiling water. Playing good time is a controlled intensity. The really good musicians can create this time feeling regardless of the style or tempo of the music. All of the great musicians have a strong sense of time.

To play good time is more natural for some than for others. To develop good time takes a strong commitment to using your ears and feelings and concentration when playing. As a bassist, to be able to groove is a must.

As a teacher I have found that if a person is having problems with time it is usually not because of inability but rather due to distractions. Often there is a physical

hindrance like not being able to execute the things one is trying to play. Most common is a lack of priorities concerning the different aspects of music making. Simply the *time* needs to be more important than the notes. I once had a pianist say to me, "No matter how many hot licks you play, if they're not in time they just don't make it." When you are playing, try to emulate that feeling which you experience while listening to the great players. Remember that the groove comes from a repetition of pulse, not speed or aggression. Playing good time gives you the same feeling as when you are walking and not conscious of your step. If your mind is preoccupied and your pace is not interrupted your steps will naturally fall into a rhythm, and when you become aware of this rhythm it feels as though you can't stop walking. This feeling is a "groove". When you are playing good time everything you play will just seem to flow. For me it is as though time is always going. I just have to pick the tempo and jump aboard. The trick is not to upset the train.

It is important to practice *in time* as your practice habits will strongly affect your performance. In this book some exercises will fall in time better than others. This is because each exercise was written with the emphasis on what to play rather than the ease of execution. The tempo should be slow enough to allow you to play each exercise non-stop with no mistakes. Remember, we are building a set of habits.

Blues Lines

Half-Step

As music moves there is a building of tension and then a release. This kind of movement is common to most music and can happen many times, and on many different levels, in a single piece. In jazz, a good walking bass line is constantly *building* and *releasing* tension. There are many ways to create tension while playing a bass line. The simplest and probably most common way of doing this is to use the “half-step approach”. The half-step approach precedes a stable tone, such as the root of a chord, by a pitch one half-step above or below.

Example #1



Certain half-step notes will sound more dissonant than others, depending on the quality of the chords and the chordal movement.

Example #2



Example #3



Which half-step, and how frequently it is used, will determine the amount of harmonic tension produced. Listen to any of the great bassists and you will hear these half-step approaches.

In creating a walking bass line, let us start with a basic jazz blues.

Example #4 Blues form and chord changes (roots only)

Example #4 shows a walking bass line in 4/4 time, featuring a key signature of one flat (Bb). The chords are F7, Bb7, and F7. The bass line consists of quarter notes and eighth notes, following the roots of the chords.

Example #5 Roots and half-step below

Example #5 shows a walking bass line in 4/4 time, featuring a key signature of one flat (Bb). The chords are F7, Bb7, and F7. The bass line consists of quarter notes and eighth notes, following the roots of the chords. A half-step movement is shown on beat 4 of the first staff, where the bass line moves from Bb to B.

Notice how the half-step on beat 4 leads to the downbeat of the next chord.

Example #6 Roots and half-step above

Example #6 shows a walking bass line in 4/4 time, featuring a key signature of one flat (Bb). The chords are F7, Bb7, and F7. The bass line consists of quarter notes and eighth notes, following the roots of the chords. A half-step movement is shown on beat 4 of the first staff, where the bass line moves from Bb to B.

It is important to practice these exercises using both *above* and *below* half-step approaches. I suggest learning the blues in three keys, playing only the roots and half-steps above until your ear is thoroughly familiar with this sound. Then play the same blues — but now with the roots and half-steps below. Practice until this sound is in your ears and fingers. The next step is a combination of both half-step approaches.

Example #7 Roots and half-step above and below



The pitfall to avoid here is that of only playing those half-steps which fall easily under your fingers. Make yourself use both *above* and *below* half-steps until you can easily switch between the two. Ultimately you want your *ear* to decide which notes to play, not your hands.

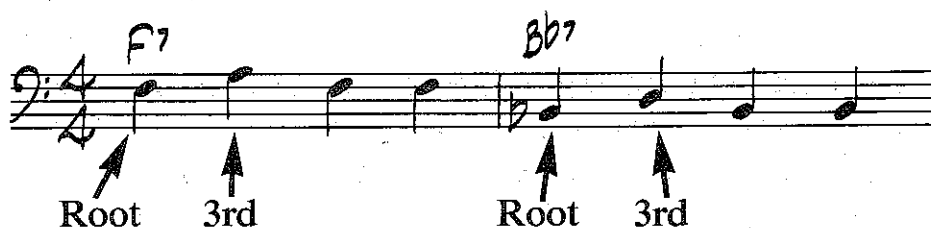
Chord-Tones

The next step in developing our walking bass line is to do something with *repeated root tones*. The options can be grouped into three categories:

- Chord Tones
- Scales
- Chromatics

Let us start with roots and one other designated chord tone. Where to play this new pitch within the measure is a matter of choice, but for now let's keep the root on the strong beats (1 and 3) and let us assume there will be a half-step approach note on beat 4 leading to the next chord. That leaves beat 2 for our new chord tone. The first chord tone above the root we will use is the 3rd:

Example #8 Root, 3rd, root



Example #9 Blues bass line using roots and 3rds



In the next example we will use the roots and 3rds plus the half-step leading to the next measure:

Example #10 Roots, 3rds, and half-steps



At this point you should begin the practice of transposing each completed exercise by ear to all other keys. Begin by choosing a key which you feel will be easiest, and learn the exercise thoroughly before moving on to the next key. If necessary write out the exercise in the new key. With patience and much practice, transposing by ear will help you develop a sense of freedom when improvising. This practice of transposing is not easy. In the beginning it may take you a long time to learn one blues in all twelve keys. However, this is an extremely important skill — so stay with it.

The next note to add to our blues bass line is the 5th of the chord. Let us place the 5th on $\sharp 2$ where before we had the 3rd.

break

ample #11 Roots and 5ths



ample #12 Roots, 5ths, and half-steps



The remaining chord tone is the 7th. In the next two examples we will use the 7th beat 2 of each measure:

Example #13 Roots and 7ths

Example #13 shows three staves of music in 4/4 time, focusing on the roots and 7ths of chords. The notes are written in bass clef. The chord labels above the staves are:

- Staff 1: F^7 , B^b7 , F^7
- Staff 2: B^b7 , F^7
- Staff 3: Gm^7 , C^7 , F^7 , C^7

Example #14 Roots, 7ths, and half-steps

Example #14 shows three staves of music in 4/4 time, focusing on the roots, 7ths, and half-steps of chords. The notes are written in bass clef. The chord labels above the staves are:

- Staff 1: F^7 , B^b7 , F^7
- Staff 2: B^b7 , F^7
- Staff 3: Gm^7 , C^7 , F^7 , C^7

So far we have used: *roots, 3rds, 5ths, 7ths*, and *half-steps*. It is very important to learn to hear and play this type of melodic movement. The next group of exercises uses these same pitches but arranged differently within the measure. Again I encourage you to memorize these lines and transpose to all keys. Work slowly and thoroughly.

Example #15 *Roots and 3rds The 3rd is now placed on beat 3*

Example #16 *Roots, 3rds, and half-steps
The 3rd is on beat 3 and the half-step is on beat 4*

Example #17 Roots and 5ths (5th on beat 3)

Example #17: Roots and 5ths (5th on beat 3). The notation shows a sequence of chords and their roots and 5ths. The chords are F7, Bb7, F7, Gm7, C7, F7, and C7. The roots and 5ths are indicated by notes on the staff. The 5th is on beat 3 for each chord.

Example #18 Roots, 5ths, and half-steps

Example #18: Roots, 5ths, and half-steps. The notation shows a sequence of chords and their roots, 5ths, and half-steps. The chords are F7, Bb7, F7, Gm7, C7, F7, and C7. The roots, 5ths, and half-steps are indicated by notes on the staff. The half-step is indicated by a sharp sign on the 5th line of the middle staff.

Example #19 Roots and 7ths (7th on beat 3)

Example #19: Roots and 7ths (7th on beat 3). The notation shows a sequence of chords and their roots and 7ths. The chords are F7, Bb7, F7, Gm7, C7, F7, and C7. The roots and 7ths are indicated by notes on the staff. The 7th is on beat 3 for each chord.

Example #20 Roots, 7ths, and half-steps

Example #20 shows three staves of bass clef music in 4/4 time. The first staff contains a 4-measure phrase with chords F^7 , Bb^7 , and F^7 . The second staff contains a 4-measure phrase with chords Bb^7 , F^7 , and a final measure with a sharp sign. The third staff contains a 4-measure phrase with chords Gm^7 , C^7 , F^7 , and C^7 . Chord tones are written above the notes, and a label $(R \ R \ 7th \ 1/2)$ is under the first measure of the first staff.

In the next four examples I have placed chord tones other than the root on beat 1 of each measure. This is common in a good bass line, but its success depends on what follows in the rest of the measure.

Example #21 The 3rd is on beat 1 with the half-step on beat 4
Notice how the half-step leads to beat 1 of the next measure which is no longer the root of the chord:

Example #21 shows three staves of bass clef music in 4/4 time. The first staff contains a 4-measure phrase with chords F^7 , Bb^7 , F^7 , and a half-step (H) on beat 4. The second staff contains a 4-measure phrase with chords Bb^7 , F^7 , and a half-step (H) on beat 4. The third staff contains a 4-measure phrase with chords Gm^7 , C^7 , F^7 , and C^7 . Chord tones are written above the notes, and a label (H) is under the fourth measure of the first staff.

In the following example I have indicated all the numbers (chord tones and half-steps) for each note. This is only to show how these particular tones are used in a walking bass line.

Example #22

X

Three staves of musical notation for the 'F7' exercise. Each staff shows a sequence of notes with fingerings and rests. The first staff starts with an F7 chord, the second with a Bb7 chord, and the third with a Gm7 chord. The notation includes various note values and rests, with fingerings indicated by numbers 1-7 and 1/2.

After you have learned to play the next two examples, analyze them to find out which notes were used.

Example #23

Handwritten musical notation for three staves in bass clef, 4/4 time. The first staff has a key signature of one flat (Bb) and a common time signature (C). The second staff has a key signature of two flats (Bb, Eb) and a common time signature (C). The third staff has a key signature of one flat (Bb) and a common time signature (C). The notation includes various chords and melodic lines.

mple #24

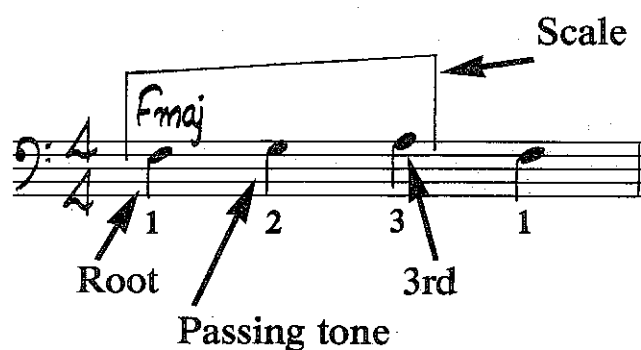


Keep in mind that these bass lines you have learned so far are only exercises. To create a solid and melodic line requires a combination of all these sounds and more. Again I urge you to learn each different pattern thoroughly. Write out on paper your own versions of these lines using all combinations of *roots*, *3rds*, *5ths*, *7ths*, *octaves* and *half-steps*.

Scales

Using scalar patterns is a common way to smooth out a bass line. By their own nature of stepwise motion, scales sound linear — which is often desirable in a bass line. Because of the moving chord changes of a song, usually only a small portion of a scale is used at one time. This becomes (in its simplest form): *chord tone - passing tone - chord tone*.

mple #25



In the next five examples we will use specific scale patterns along with half-steps:

Example #26 Scale steps 1, 2, 3, 1

Example #26 shows three staves of music in bass clef with a 4/4 time signature. The first staff features a scale pattern with fingerings 1, 2, 3, 1, 1, 2, 3, 1, 1, 2, 3, 1, and a 'simile' instruction. The second staff shows a descending scale pattern. The third staff shows a scale pattern with accidentals. Chord symbols F^7 , Bb^7 , Gm^7 , and C^7 are written above the notes.

Example #27 Scale steps 1, 2, 3, half-steps

Example #27 shows three staves of music in bass clef with a 4/4 time signature. The first staff features a scale pattern with fingerings 1, 2, 3, $\frac{1}{2}$, 1, 2, 3, $\frac{1}{2}$. The second staff shows a descending scale pattern. The third staff shows a scale pattern with accidentals. Chord symbols F^7 , Bb^7 , Gm^7 , and C^7 are written above the notes.

Example #28 Scale steps 1, 2, 3, 5 or half-step

Example #28 shows three staves of music in bass clef with a 4/4 time signature. The first staff features a scale pattern with fingerings 1, 2, 3, 5, 1, 2, 3, $\frac{1}{2}$. The second staff shows a descending scale pattern. The third staff shows a scale pattern with accidentals. Chord symbols F^7 , Bb^7 , Gm^7 , and C^7 are written above the notes.

Example #29 Scale steps 1, 7, 6, 1

Example #29 is a musical exercise in 4/4 time, featuring three staves. The first staff (treble clef) shows the scale steps 1, 7, 6, 1, with chords F^7 , Bb^7 , and F^7 indicated above. The second staff (treble clef) continues the scale, with chords Bb^7 , F^7 , and F^7 indicated above. The third staff (bass clef) shows the scale steps 1, 7, 6, 1, with chords Gm^7 , C^7 , F^7 , and C^7 indicated above. The scale is in the key of F major, with notes F, C, G, and F in the first staff, and Bb, F, C, and F in the second staff.

Example #30 Scale steps 1, 7, 6, 5 or half-step

Example #30 is a musical exercise in 4/4 time, featuring three staves. The first staff (treble clef) shows the scale steps 1, 7, 6, 5, with chords F^7 , Bb^7 , and F^7 indicated above. The second staff (treble clef) continues the scale, with chords Bb^7 , F^7 , and F^7 indicated above. The third staff (bass clef) shows the scale steps 1, 7, 6, 5, with chords Gm^7 , C^7 , F^7 , and C^7 indicated above. The scale is in the key of F major, with notes F, C, G, and F in the first staff, and Bb, F, C, and F in the second staff.

Chromatics

Chromatic notes are generally used within a scale passage or as a leading tone to a more stable pitch. Many of the half-step approach notes we have used are chromatics. Here is an example of some commonly used chromatic notes:

Example #31 Chromatics*

Chromatic notes can be used to suspend the tension created by a moving line. The next examples illustrate how to suspend tension by using chromatic pitches:

Example #32 (No chromatic)

Example #32A Chromatic*

Example #32B Chromatic*



In Example #32 motion is created by the stepwise motion of the last three beats. By adding the G# in Example #32A, the stepwise motion is extended throughout the entire measure. In Example #32B the F# is used to also extend the stepwise motion.

Notice how the G# in Example #32A leads strongly to the third of the chord. This A is the 7th of the following chord and leads more strongly to the root. In Example #32B the F# leads not to a chord tone but to a scale step. This is not as strong a resolution, so there feels a need for continued movement. Both examples 32A and 32B create a strong sense of direction to the next measure.

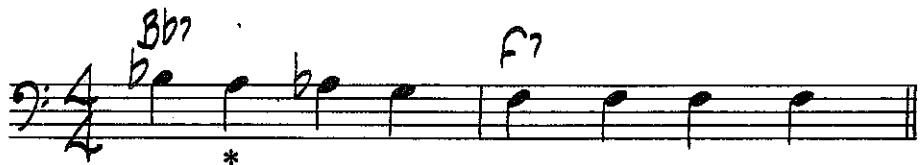
Tension and Release

The use of chromatics enables one to create a stronger *pull* toward a specific point. Where the chromatic is placed in the line determines where the tension is created and then released. The next two examples show a contrast in placement and in turn a difference of where stability, tension and ultimately resolution occurs:

Example #33



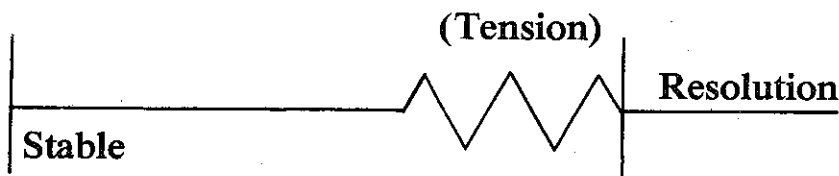
Example #33A



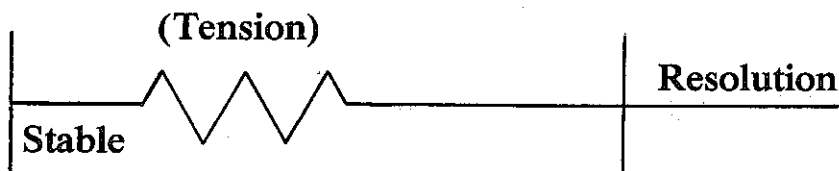
Example #33 uses the chromatic in the last part of the measure, while Example #33A places the chromatic in the first half of the measure. The pattern of *stability - tension - release* may be shown in a graph such as the one below:

ample #34

ample #33)



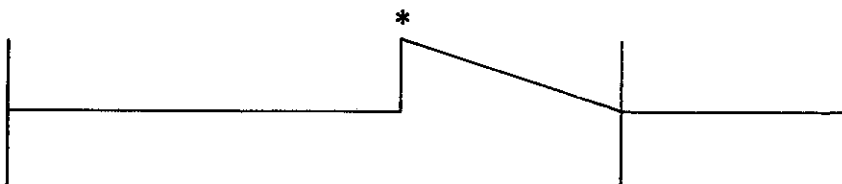
ample #33A)



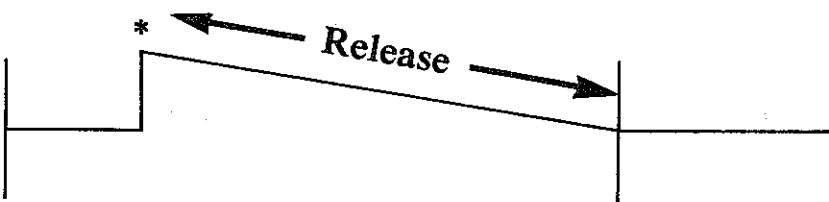
Notice in these graphs the difference in time of the release:

ample #35

ample #33)



ample #33A)



* = Appearance of chromatic

In Example #33 the chromatic note appears as the last quarter note. This leaves the first three beats fairly stable in sound with a sudden tension and quick release as the root appears in the next measure on beat 1. However, in Example #33A the chromatic appears in beat 2 and leaves a longer release to beat 1 of the next measure.

By using scale patterns and chromatics we can create very long linear lines with the tensions being suspended as we desire. In the next example I have used brackets to show scale passages which may or may not include chromatics:

Example #36

Example #36 is a musical score for three staves, likely representing a piano, guitar, and bass. The top staff is in 4/4 time and features a series of chords: F7, Bb7, F7, and F7. A bracket labeled "Scale with chromatics" spans the first two measures. The middle staff continues the harmonic progression with Bb7, F7, and F7. The bottom staff shows Gm7, C7, F7, and C7. The notation includes various accidentals and scale runs, with some notes marked with a sharp sign (#).

Examples #37 and 38 illustrate some of the more common examples of chromatics used in blues lines:

Example #37

Example #37 is a musical score for three staves, similar to Example #36. The top staff features F7, Bb7, F7, and F7. The middle staff shows Bb7, F7, and F7. The bottom staff includes Gm7, C7, F7, and C7. The notation includes various accidentals and scale runs, with some notes marked with a sharp sign (#).

Sample #38

Handwritten musical score for "The Girl on the Train" by Rachel Watson. The score is written on three staves in bass clef, 4/4 time. The melody is composed of eighth and quarter notes. Chords are indicated by handwritten labels above the notes: F7, Bb7, F7, Gm7, C7, F7, and C7. The piece concludes with a double bar line.

II-V-I

Diatonic Harmony/Seventh Chords

Jazz harmony, like traditional harmony, is derived from chords built on the steps of a scale. These chords are built by stacking notes in thirds on top of each scale degree:

Example #39 7th chords built on the degrees of a C major scale

Diagram showing 7th chords built on the degrees of a C major scale, numbered with Roman numerals:

Scale Degree	Chord Name	Roman Numeral
I	Cmaj ⁷	I
II	Dmin ⁷	II
III	Emin ⁷	III
IV	Fmaj ⁷	IV
V	G ⁷	V
VI	Amin ⁷	VI
VII	Bmin ⁷ (b5)	VII
I	Cmaj ⁷	I

As you can see, each scale degree has been numbered using Roman numerals.

If you spell each of the chords built, you will find the quality of each chord respectively

I = Major 7 II = minor 7 III = minor 7 IV = Major 7

V = dominant 7 VI = minor 7 VII = minor 7 (b5)

The minor 7 (b5) chord has another name which is commonly used. It is "half diminished" and is written: $\emptyset$. These qualities remain the same for chords built on any major scale. Only the letter names change for each scale.

Example #40 Chord qualities in various keys

The image displays four staves of music, each containing eight chords. The chords are arranged in a sequence that follows the circle of fifths. The chords and their qualities are as follows:

- Staff 1: Fmaj⁷, Gm⁷, Am⁷, B^bmaj⁷, C⁷, Dm⁷, E^ø⁷, Fmaj⁷
- Staff 2: A⁺maj⁷, Bm⁷, C[#]m⁷, Dmaj⁷, E⁷, F[#]m⁷, G[#]^ø⁷, A⁺maj⁷
- Staff 3: Gmaj⁷, Am⁷, Bm⁷, Cmaj⁷, D⁷, Em⁷, F[#]^ø⁷, Gmaj⁷
- Staff 4: B^bmaj⁷, Cm⁷, Dm⁷, E^bmaj⁷, F⁷, Gm⁷, A^ø⁷, B^bmaj⁷

The same arrangement of chords and qualities is true for all of the other major scales as well.

When various chords from a scale are played in a sequence, this is called a “chord progression”. *Harmony* is the general name given to all types of chord progressions.

In harmony there are some chord progressions that are more common than others. In jazz a very common chord progression is the movement from a IImin⁷ to a V⁷ to a I⁺maj⁷. This is a very strong progression as it leads to the I chord which is a point of rest. Movement away from a point of stability and back to a point of rest is called a *cadence*. II-V-I is a common jazz cadence. This pattern of chords can be found in abundance in standard jazz tunes. This specific chord progression is used even more frequently by jazz musicians when improvising. Often this pattern is implied in a jazz solo, even when these specific chords are not present in the accompaniment.

As a jazz bassist it is most important to learn the sound of the II-V-I progression and be able to play a bass line over these chords with ease in all keys.

Piano Voicings and Tensions

The following is a II-V-I in the key of C major. Go to the piano and play these chords

Example #41 II-V-I progression

Example #41 shows a II-V-I progression in C major. The right hand plays the triads for Dm⁷, G⁷, and Cmaj⁷. The left hand plays the root notes (D, G, and C) as single notes.

Common among good jazz pianists is the use of tension and altered notes when voicing a chord. The following three examples illustrate some of the more standard voicings a jazz pianist might use when playing a II-V-I progression. I have added the bass note in the lower staff. Play this note with the left hand while playing the chord in the right hand. Listen to the sound of the total sonority:

Example #42 II-V-I (jazz voicing)

Example #42 shows a II-V-I progression in C major with jazz voicing. The right hand plays the triads with the 9th (Dm⁹, G⁹, and Cmaj⁹). The left hand plays the root notes (D, G, and C) as single notes.

Example #43 II-V-I (jazz voicing)

Example #43 shows a II-V-I progression in C major with jazz voicing. The right hand plays the triads with the 9th and a flat 9th (Dm⁹, G^{7(b9)}, and Cmaj⁹). The left hand plays the root notes (D, G, and C) as single notes.

Example #44 II-V-I (jazz voicing)

Example #44 shows a II-V-I progression in C major with jazz voicing. The right hand plays the triads with the 9th and a flat 9th (Dm⁹, G¹³, and Cmaj⁹). The left hand plays the root notes (D, G, and C) as single notes.

Learning to recognize the sounds of these chordal movements will be invaluable in ultimately creating good sounding bass lines. I strongly suggest that you learn to play examples 43 and 44 on the piano. Here is one procedure for practicing these II-V-I progressions in all keys:

Example #45 II-V-I in all keys

The first system of music shows a II-V-I progression in C major: Dm⁹, G¹³, and Cmaj⁹. The second system shows the same progression in Bb major: Bbm⁹, Eb¹³, and Abmaj⁹. An arrow points to the right with the text "etc." indicating the progression continues through all twelve keys.

For those of you who may not have any prior training on the piano, this task may seem impossible. If you work at it slowly and consistently the benefits will be greater than you can imagine at this time. Always practice in time and strive for accuracy. The maxim should always be "quality, not quantity".

Example #46 is written as chord changes would be notated for the piano. Practice the voicings from both examples 43 and 44.

Example #46 II-V-I (chord chart)

The chart displays three systems of II-V-I progressions in all twelve keys. The first system is C major: Dm⁹, G¹³, Cmaj⁹. The second system is Bb major: Bbm⁹, Eb¹³, Abmaj⁹. The third system is F# major: F#m⁹, B¹³, Emaj⁹. Each system shows the chord changes for the II, V, and I chords in that key.

To play the chord progression in the other six keys start on Eb and follow the same procedure

Example #47 II-V-I (chord chart)

Chord chart for Example #47 (II-V-I) in three systems of treble clef staves:

- System 1: Ebm9, Ab13, Dbmaj9, C#m9, F#13, Bmaj9
- System 2: Bm9, E13, Amaj9, Am9, D13, Gmaj9
- System 3: Gm9, C13, Fmaj9, Fm9, Bb13, Ebmaj9

Bossa Nova

Let us start the II-V-I exercises playing in the Bossa Nova style with roots only. The basic rhythm pattern for Bossa Nova is a dotted quarter note followed by an eighth note.

Example #48 II-V-I roots only Bossa Nova

Musical notation for Example #48 (II-V-I roots only Bossa Nova) in three systems of bass clef staves:

- System 1: Dm7, G7, Cmaj7 (with a melodic line)
- System 2: Em7, A7, Dmaj7 (with a rhythmic pattern labeled "Simile")
- System 3: Dm7, G7, Cmaj7 (with a rhythmic pattern)

At this stage it would help immensely if you could find someone to play the chords along with your bass line. The goal is to learn the sound of the II-V-I and the different patterns of movement for II-Vs in general. Recognizing the sound of a particular chord progression is how a good bass player functions.

Here are some common variations on the basic Bossa Nova bass line:

sample #484



In the following examples stay with roots only.
Concentrate on the chord movement and the time. If
you are playing alone, try to hear the sounds of the chords
in your head.

Example #49 II-V-I

Example #49 II-V-I is written in 4/4 time, bass clef. It consists of three systems of chords, each with a 4-measure duration indicated by four diagonal strokes. The first system contains Dm⁷, G⁷, and Cmaj⁷. The second system contains Cm⁷, F⁷, and B^bmaj⁷. The third system contains B^bm⁷, E^b⁷, and A^bmaj⁷.

Example #50 II-V-I

Example #50 II-V-I is written in 4/4 time, bass clef. It consists of three systems of chords, each with a 4-measure duration indicated by four diagonal strokes. The first system contains Dm⁷, G⁷, and Cmaj⁷. The second system contains E^m⁷, A⁷, and Dmaj⁷. The third system contains F[#]m⁷, B⁷, and E^maj⁷.

Example #51 II-V-I

Example #51 II-V-I is written in 4/4 time, bass clef. It consists of three systems of chords, each with a 4-measure duration indicated by four diagonal strokes. The first system contains Dm⁷, G⁷, and Cmaj⁷. The second system contains A^m⁷, D⁷, and Gmaj⁷. The third system contains E^m⁷, A⁷, and Dmaj⁷.

Example #52 II-V-I

Handwritten musical notation for Example #52, II-V-I progression in D minor. The notation is written on six staves, each containing four measures of music. The chords are written above the staves:

- Staff 1: Dm⁷, G⁷, Cmaj⁷
- Staff 2: Cm⁷, F⁷, Bbmaj⁷
- Staff 3: Bbm⁷, Eb⁷, Abmaj⁷
- Staff 4: Abm⁷, Db⁷, Gbmaj⁷
- Staff 5: F#m⁷, B⁷, Emaj⁷
- Staff 6: Em⁷, A⁷, Dmaj⁷

Example #53 II-V-I

Handwritten musical notation for Example #53, II-V-I progression in E-flat major. The notation is written on six staves, each containing four measures of music. The chords are written above the staves:

- Staff 1: Ebm⁷, Ab⁷, Dbmaj⁷
- Staff 2: C#m⁷, F#⁷, Bmaj⁷
- Staff 3: Bm⁷, E⁷, Amaj⁷
- Staff 4: Am⁷, D⁷, Gmaj⁷
- Staff 5: Gm⁷, C⁷, Fmaj⁷
- Staff 6: Fm⁷, Bb⁷, Ebmaj⁷

Example #54 II-V-I

Handwritten musical notation for Example #54, II-V-I progression in bass clef, 4/4 time. The notation consists of three staves, each with four measures. The first staff contains the chords Dm⁷, G⁷, and Cmaj⁷. The second staff contains the chords F#m⁷, B⁷, and E⁷maj⁷. The third staff contains the chords Bbm⁷, Eb⁷, and Ab⁷maj⁷. Each measure is filled with diagonal lines representing a walking bass line.

Example #55 II-V-I

Handwritten musical notation for Example #55, II-V-I progression in bass clef, 4/4 time. The notation consists of four staves, each with four measures. The first staff contains the chords Dm⁷, G⁷, and Cmaj⁷. The second staff contains the chords Bbm⁷, Eb⁷, and Ab⁷maj⁷. The third staff contains the chords F#m⁷, B⁷, and E⁷maj⁷. The fourth staff contains the chords Dm⁷, G⁷, and Cmaj⁷. Each measure is filled with diagonal lines representing a walking bass line.

Example #56 II-V-I

Handwritten musical notation for Example #56 II-V-I, showing six staves of chords in bass clef. Each staff contains four measures of music, with the first three measures containing a chord and the fourth measure being empty. The chords are as follows:

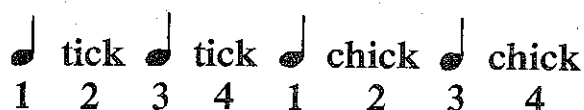
- Staff 1: Dm⁷, G⁷, Cmaj⁷
- Staff 2: Em⁷, A⁷, Dmaj⁷
- Staff 3: F#m⁷, B⁷, Emaj⁷
- Staff 4: Abm⁷, Db⁷, Gbmaj⁷
- Staff 5: Bbm⁷, Eb⁷, Abmaj⁷
- Staff 6: Cm⁷, F⁷, Bbmaj⁷

Two-Beat Swing

The next group of examples are also based on the II, V, I progression but played in a Two-Beat style. In a jazz setting this two-beat is commonly used in the first chorus or two of a tune as a preface building to a walking four-four. This style is epitomized in Ray Brown's playing with Oscar Peterson on recordings made during the 1950's and 1960's. Scott LaFaro also often played in two with Bill Evans, but with a much different feel. This type of playing led to what is now commonly called a "broken time feel".

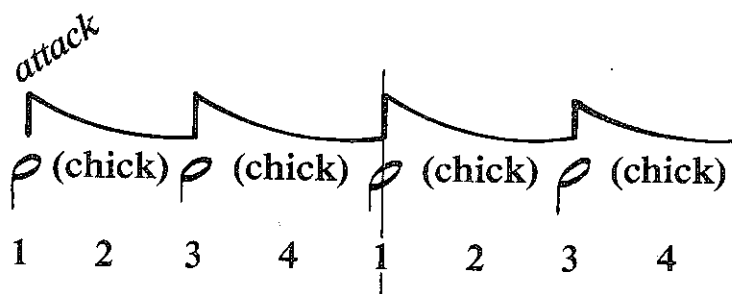
Playing in two is exactly the same as walking in four, but with less notes. When playing two-beat it is important to make the time flow linearly. You must feel the time on all beats even though you are not playing all the beats. If you can swing in two, four-four will come easily. For this reason I suggest you practice playing in two.

When playing the following examples use the metronome ticking on beats 2 and 4. At first this may be difficult, but go slowly. Imagine the ticks as hi-hats:



Let your bass notes ring until the next note is played. If you could see the sound it might look like this:

Example #57



Notice the continuous line of sound. This sustaining sound will help to maintain the linear flow of the energy and time.

Play all of the following two-beat exercises with the metronome ticking on 2 and 4. Notice how the use of quarter notes in various places effects the overall motion of the line. Depending on where the quarter notes are placed, the emphasis can be shifted around between measures or chords. Often the quarter notes simply lead into the next chord change.

Example #58 Two-Beat (II-V-I) Chord tones and half-steps

The exercises are as follows:

- Staff 1: Dm7 (F, A, C), G7 (B, D, F), Cmaj7 (E, G, B, C)
- Staff 2: Dm7 (F, A, C), G7 (B, D, F), Cmaj7 (E, G, B, C)
- Staff 3: Dm7 (F, A, C), G7 (B, D, F), Cmaj7 (E, G, B, C)
- Staff 4: Dm7 (F, A, C), G7 (B, D, F), Cmaj7 (E, G, B, C)
- Staff 5: Dm7 (F, A, C), G7 (B, D, F), Cmaj7 (E, G, B, C)
- Staff 6: Dm7 (F, A, C), G7 (B, D, F), Cmaj7 (E, G, B, C)
- Staff 7: Dm7 (F, A, C), G7 (B, D, F), Cmaj7 (E, G, B, C)
- Staff 8: Dm7 (F, A, C), G7 (B, D, F), Cmaj7 (E, G, B, C)
- Staff 9: Dm7 (F, A, C), G7 (B, D, F), Cmaj7 (E, G, B, C)
- Staff 10: Dm7 (F, A, C), G7 (B, D, F), Cmaj7 (E, G, B, C)
- Staff 11: Dm7 (F, A, C), G7 (B, D, F), Cmaj7 (E, G, B, C)
- Staff 12: Dm7 (F, A, C), G7 (B, D, F), Cmaj7 (E, G, B, C)

The next exercise is similar to the previous one, but in a new key and with slightly different placements of the quarter notes.

Example #59 *Two-Beat (II-V-I) Chord tones and half-steps*

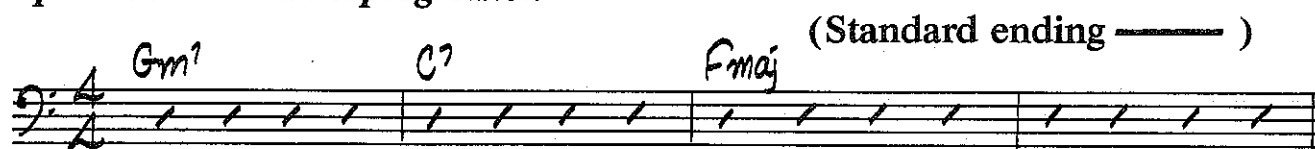
The exercise consists of 12 staves, each representing a two-beat II-V-I progression in Bb major. The chords are Bbm7, Eb7, and Abmaj7. The notes are placed on a single staff for each progression, with the first beat containing the Bbm7 notes and the second beat containing the Eb7 and Abmaj7 notes. The notes are as follows:

- Staff 1: Bbm7 (Bb, D, F, Ab), Eb7 (Eb, G, Bb, D), Abmaj7 (Ab, C, Eb, G, Bb)
- Staff 2: Bbm7 (Bb, D, F, Ab), Eb7 (Eb, G, Bb, D), Abmaj7 (Ab, C, Eb, G, Bb)
- Staff 3: Bbm7 (Bb, D, F, Ab), Eb7 (Eb, G, Bb, D), Abmaj7 (Ab, C, Eb, G, Bb)
- Staff 4: Bbm7 (Bb, D, F, Ab), Eb7 (Eb, G, Bb, D), Abmaj7 (Ab, C, Eb, G, Bb)
- Staff 5: Bbm7 (Bb, D, F, Ab), Eb7 (Eb, G, Bb, D), Abmaj7 (Ab, C, Eb, G, Bb)
- Staff 6: Bbm7 (Bb, D, F, Ab), Eb7 (Eb, G, Bb, D), Abmaj7 (Ab, C, Eb, G, Bb)
- Staff 7: Bbm7 (Bb, D, F, Ab), Eb7 (Eb, G, Bb, D), Abmaj7 (Ab, C, Eb, G, Bb)
- Staff 8: Bbm7 (Bb, D, F, Ab), Eb7 (Eb, G, Bb, D), Abmaj7 (Ab, C, Eb, G, Bb)
- Staff 9: Bbm7 (Bb, D, F, Ab), Eb7 (Eb, G, Bb, D), Abmaj7 (Ab, C, Eb, G, Bb)
- Staff 10: Bbm7 (Bb, D, F, Ab), Eb7 (Eb, G, Bb, D), Abmaj7 (Ab, C, Eb, G, Bb)
- Staff 11: Bbm7 (Bb, D, F, Ab), Eb7 (Eb, G, Bb, D), Abmaj7 (Ab, C, Eb, G, Bb)
- Staff 12: Bbm7 (Bb, D, F, Ab), Eb7 (Eb, G, Bb, D), Abmaj7 (Ab, C, Eb, G, Bb)

Turnarounds

Turnaround is a jazz term which defines a series of chords. A turnaround is similar to a cadence, but with one very important difference. A cadence usually leads to a point of rest. A turnaround ends with a feeling of needing to go on. When used at the end of a song or phrase a turnaround helps to continue the harmonic motion, typically for a soloist to play another chorus. Turnarounds are used in many situations to create tension which releases into the next phrase. Example #60 shows how a turnaround might be used in a standard jazz tune:

Example #60 Standard progression



Example #60A Turnaround



The next set of examples show a turnaround played in a Two-Beat style. Practice these exercises until you can play the entire group nonstop. Notice how the different placement of the quarter note half-step changes the feel of the turnaround.

Example #61 Turnarounds, two-beat, chord tones and half-steps
(Remember to use the metronome on 2 and 4)

The image displays ten musical staves, each representing a different turnaround exercise in 4/4 time. Each staff consists of four measures, with chords and notes written above and below the staff lines. The chords are F7, D7, Gm7, and C7. The notes are half notes, and the exercises focus on different half-step movements between the chords.

- Staff 1: F7 (F4, A4, C5), D7 (D4, F4, A4), Gm7 (Bb3, D4, F4), C7 (Eb3, G3, Bb3)
- Staff 2: F7 (F4, A4, C5), D7 (D4, F4, A4), Gm7 (Bb3, D4, F4), C7 (Eb3, G3, Bb3)
- Staff 3: F7 (F4, A4, C5), D7 (D4, F4, A4), Gm7 (Bb3, D4, F4), C7 (Eb3, G3, Bb3)
- Staff 4: F7 (F4, A4, C5), D7 (D4, F4, A4), Gm7 (Bb3, D4, F4), C7 (Eb3, G3, Bb3)
- Staff 5: F7 (F4, A4, C5), D7 (D4, F4, A4), Gm7 (Bb3, D4, F4), C7 (Eb3, G3, Bb3)
- Staff 6: F7 (F4, A4, C5), D7 (D4, F4, A4), Gm7 (Bb3, D4, F4), C7 (Eb3, G3, Bb3)
- Staff 7: F7 (F4, A4, C5), D7 (D4, F4, A4), Gm7 (Bb3, D4, F4), C7 (Eb3, G3, Bb3)
- Staff 8: F7 (F4, A4, C5), D7 (D4, F4, A4), Gm7 (Bb3, D4, F4), C7 (Eb3, G3, Bb3)
- Staff 9: F7 (F4, A4, C5), D7 (D4, F4, A4), Gm7 (Bb3, D4, F4), C7 (Eb3, G3, Bb3)
- Staff 10: F7 (F4, A4, C5), D7 (D4, F4, A4), Gm7 (Bb3, D4, F4), C7 (Eb3, G3, Bb3)

The various placements of the quarter notes and half-steps in Example #61 give an indication of the wide range of possibilities available when improvising a bass line. An improvised bass line probably would not be played with the choices layed out so orderly, but a good bass player would be capable of using all the different choices at will. More important than playing all of the different variations of a bass line is knowing when to use a specific note or rhythm to embellish the line. The great bass players can very subtly add a note or change a pitch of a repeated pattern to create just the right amount of tension. In general, the great players do use all of the different possible note and rhythm combinations — but very sparingly. It is easy for the student to make his bass lines sound cluttered and unsteady by using too many devices. A rule of thumb for the student is “the more simple, the better”. By listening to recordings and live music played by good players, you will develop a natural feel for when to add or take away from your lines.

Example #62 Turnaround with roots and half-steps

The following table summarizes the six variations shown in Example #62:

Staff	Chord	Interval	Next Chord	Interval	Next Chord	Interval	Next Chord	Interval	Next Chord
1	F ⁷	Above	D ⁷	Below	Gm ⁷	Below	C ⁷	Below	
2	F ⁷	Below	D ⁷	Below	Gm ⁷	Below	C ⁷	Below	
3	F ⁷	(Above)	D ⁷	Below	Gm ⁷	(Below)	C ⁷		
4	F ⁷	(Below)	D ⁷	Below	Gm ⁷	(Above)	C ⁷	Below	
5	F ⁷	Above	D ⁷	Below	Gm ⁷	Above	C ⁷	Below	
6	F ⁷	Below	D ⁷	Above	Gm ⁷	Below	C ⁷	Above	

Example #63 Blues with turnaround

The musical score is written in bass clef with a 4/4 time signature. It consists of six staves of music. The chords and notes are as follows:

- Staff 1: F_7 (notes: F, A, C, E), Bb_7 (notes: Bb, Db, F, Ab), F_7 (notes: F, A, C, E), and a final measure with notes F, A, C, E and a sharp sign (#).
- Staff 2: Bb_7 (notes: Bb, Db, F, Ab), F_7 (notes: F, A, C, E), and a final measure with notes F, A, C, E and a sharp sign (#).
- Staff 3: Gm_7 (notes: G, Bb, D, F), C_7 (notes: C, Eb, G, Bb), F_7 (notes: F, A, C, E), D_7 (notes: D, F, Ab, C), Gm_7 (notes: G, Bb, D, F), and C_7 (notes: C, Eb, G, Bb).
- Staff 4: F_7 (notes: F, A, C, E), Bb_7 (notes: Bb, Db, F, Ab), F_7 (notes: F, A, C, E), and a final measure with notes F, A, C, E.
- Staff 5: Bb_7 (notes: Bb, Db, F, Ab), F_7 (notes: F, A, C, E), and a final measure with notes F, A, C, E and a sharp sign (#).
- Staff 6: Gm_7 (notes: G, Bb, D, F), C_7 (notes: C, Eb, G, Bb), F (notes: F, A, C, E), D_7 (notes: D, F, Ab, C), Gm_7 (notes: G, Bb, D, F), and C_7 (notes: C, Eb, G, Bb).

Substitute Chords

Substituting chords is a common practice in jazz. Often existing chords are replaced by different chords. This may be done for any number of reasons. Sometimes additional chords are added to create more harmonic motion, just the same as when using a turnaround. There are many situations where the use of specific substitute chords have become standard procedure. The following examples will illustrate two of the most common situations where substitute chords are used. . .

Flat V Chord

In jazz the single most common harmonic movement is that of an ascending 4th. This type of chord progression is where the b5 substitute can be used:

Example #64 Standard progression



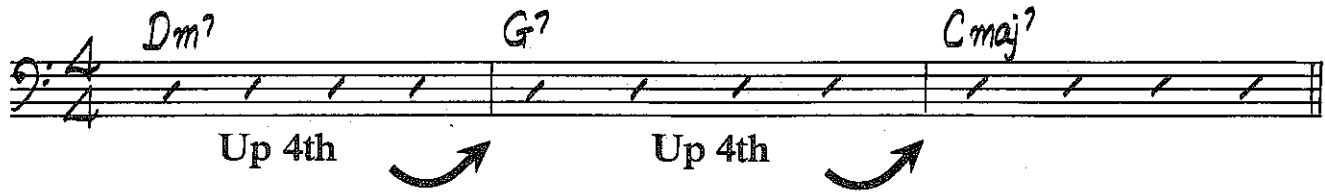
Example #64A With substitute



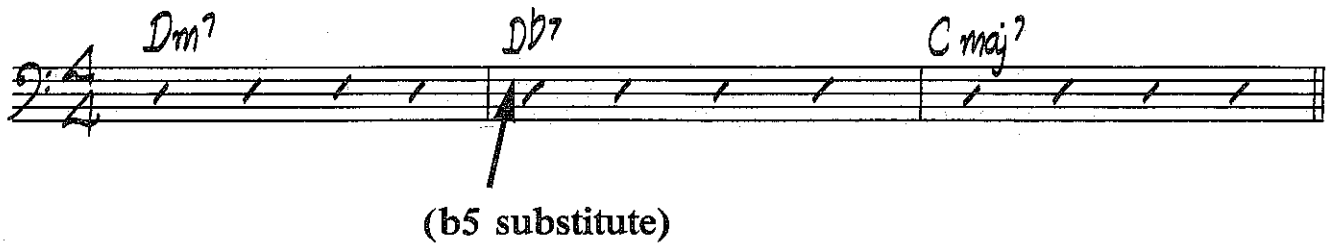
In the previous example notice that the B7 chord which is substituted for the F7 (a flattened 5th away) is also a half-step leading into the Bb7 chord. This creates a strong pull to the Bb7.

The Flat V substitute can also be used in a II-V-I.
Again the root movement of the chords is ascending 4ths:

Example #65 Standard progression



Example #65A With substitute



By using the Db7 instead of the G7 a chromatic motion is created from D to Db to C

Most commonly the Flat V substitute is a dominant chord replacing another dominant chord such as that used in a turnaround.

Flat V substitutes are used in different qualities and in many different situations. The following example shows the b5 as a dominant chord and a major 7 chord:

Example #66 Turnarounds with various substitute chords

Four musical staves showing different turnaround progressions in 4/4 time. Each staff has five measures with slash notation for the notes. The chords are written above the staves:

- Staff 1: Fmaj⁷, Dm⁷, Gm⁷, C⁷, Fmaj⁷
- Staff 2: Fmaj⁷, Abmaj⁷*, Dbmaj⁷*, Gbmaj⁷*, Fmaj⁷
- Staff 3: Fmaj⁷, Ab⁷*, Db⁷*, C⁷, Fmaj⁷
- Staff 4: F⁷, Ab⁷*, Gm⁷, C⁷, F⁷

These are just a few possible combinations of b5 substitutes in a turnaround.

In a blues progression the Flat V substitute is used frequently.

Example #67 shows how the b5 might be used in a blues:

Example #67

Three musical staves showing a blues progression in 4/4 time. Each staff has four measures with slash notation for the notes. The chords are written above the staves:

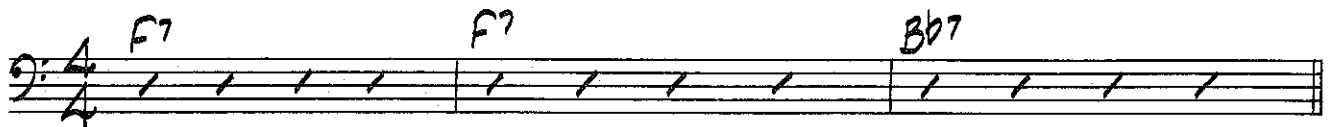
- Staff 1: F⁷, Bb⁷, F⁷, B⁷*
- Staff 2: Bb⁷, F⁷
- Staff 3: Gm⁷, C⁷, Gb⁷*, F⁷, Ab⁷*, Gm⁷, Gb⁷*

* Flat V substitute

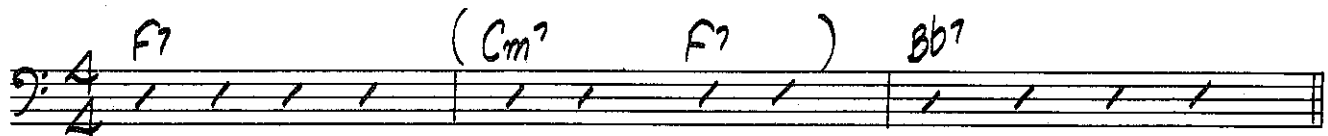
II-V Substitutes

Very common in jazz is the addition of a II-V chord progression where otherwise there is no chordal movement. This type of chord substitution creates motion. Sometimes the rhythm section plays these substitute changes and the soloist improvises accordingly. Other times the soloist may imply these chords with the accompaniment, choosing not to play the substitute chords.

Example #68 Standard progression



Example #68A With substitute



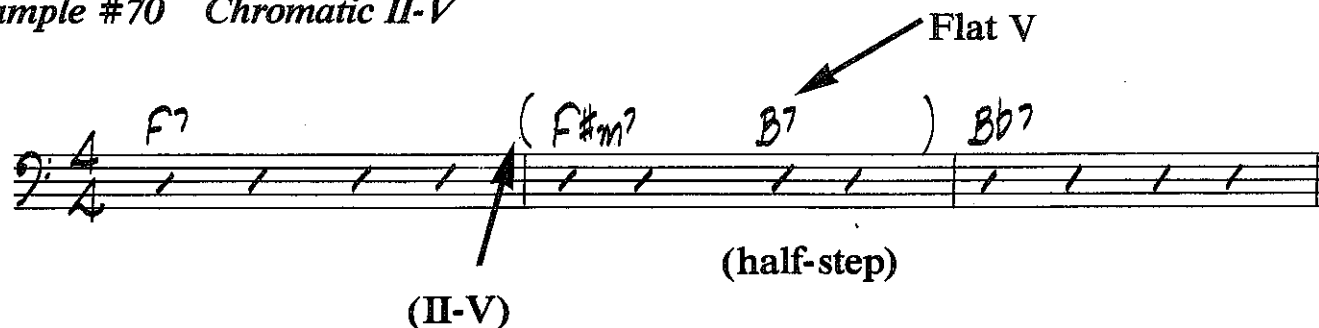
Example #69 Blues with substitute II-Vs

Chromatic II-V

The Chromatic II-V is a unique but strong approach. To build the Chromatic II-V simply place a II chord in front of a Flat V substitute chord. We now have a II-V, but it does not lead to the I chord as in a standard II-V-I chord progression. Instead the Chromatic II-V resolves chromatically down by a half-step.

The fundamental difference between the Chromatic II-V and the Flat V is the amount of tension created. The Flat V substitute can be quite subtle, while the Chromatic II-V is very noticeable.

Example #70 Chromatic II-V



With the Chromatic II-V the II chord is not always minor. It is common for the II chord to be a dominant 7th chord as well.

The following example shows:

1. Standard progression
2. II-V substitute
3. Flat V substitute
4. Chromatic II-V substitute

Example #71 Substitute chords



Example #72 Blues with chromatic II-Vs

Example #72 shows a blues progression with chromatic II-V substitutions. The chords are written above the notes in the following sequence across four measures:

- Measure 1: F7
- Measure 2: Bb7
- Measure 3: F7
- Measure 4: (F#m7 B7)

The second staff continues the progression:

- Measure 1: Bb7
- Measure 2: (C#m7 F#7)
- Measure 3: F7
- Measure 4: Am7 D7

The third staff continues the progression:

- Measure 1: Gm7
- Measure 2: (C#m7 F#7)
- Measure 3: F7 D7
- Measure 4: Db7 C7

The following set of blues choruses illustrate the use of various chords substitutions:

Example #73 Blues with substitute chords

Example #73 shows a blues progression with various substitute chords. The chords are written above the notes in the following sequence across four measures:

- Measure 1: F7
- Measure 2: Bb7
- Measure 3: F7
- Measure 4: Cm7 F7

The second staff continues the progression:

- Measure 1: Bb7
- Measure 2: Gm7 C7
- Measure 3: F7
- Measure 4: Am7 D7

The third staff continues the progression:

- Measure 1: Gm7
- Measure 2: C7
- Measure 3: F7 Ab7
- Measure 4: Db7 Gb7

Example #74 Blues with substitute chords

Example #74 shows a blues progression with various substitute chords. The chords are written above the notes in the following sequence across four measures:

- Measure 1: F7
- Measure 2: Bb7
- Measure 3: (F#m7) G7
- Measure 4: Cm7 F7

The second staff continues the progression:

- Measure 1: Bb7
- Measure 2: Am7 D7
- Measure 3: Abm7 Db7

The third staff continues the progression:

- Measure 1: Gm7
- Measure 2: Gm7 C7
- Measure 3: Am7 D7
- Measure 4: Gm7 C7

Example #75 Blues with substitute chords

Example #75 is a blues piece in 4/4 time, key of B-flat major (two flats). The melody is written on a single staff. The accompaniment is written on two staves. The chords used are: F7, Bb7, Cm7, F7, Bb7, Db7, Gb7, F7, Am7, D7, Db7, Gm7, C7, F7, D7, Gm7, C7.

Example #76 Blues with substitute chords

Example #76 is a blues piece in 4/4 time, key of B-flat major (two flats). The melody is written on a single staff. The accompaniment is written on two staves. The chords used are: F7, F#m7, B7, Bb7, Gm7, C7, F7, D7, Gm7, Db7, C7, F7, Ab7, Db7, Gb7.

Example #77 Blues with substitute chords

Example #77 is a blues piece in 4/4 time, key of B-flat major (two flats). The melody is written on a single staff. The accompaniment is written on two staves. The chords used are: F7, B7, Bb7, Bb7, F7, D7, Gm7, C7, F7, D7, Db7, C7.

Example #78 *Blues with substitute chords*

Example #78 is a blues piece in 4/4 time with a key signature of one flat (Bb). The music is written on three staves. The first staff contains the following chords: F7, Bb7, F7, Cm7, and F7. The second staff contains: Bb7, C#7, F#7, F7, Am7, and D7. The third staff contains: Gm7, C7, F7, Db7, and C7. The notation includes eighth and quarter notes, rests, and bar lines.

Summary

In closing I would like to congratulate you upon completion of this volume. I should, however, also caution you. The material presented here is but the first step in learning to play walking bass lines. It is vitally important to thoroughly master these sounds, if you wish to reach higher levels of creative playing. Remember this is your *musical foundation*. Build it solidly.

Discography

These are a few recordings illustrating classic bass lines:

Ray Brown with the Oscar Peterson Trio

Something Warm Verve V6 8681

We Get Requests Verve V6 8606

Sam Jones with the Oscar Peterson Trio

Tristeza On Piano BASF 20734

Andy Simpkins with The Three Sounds

Feeling Good Blue Note BLP 4072

Bottoms Up Blue Note BLP 4014

Paul Chambers with Red Garland

It's A Blue World Prestige 7838

Can't See For Lookin' Prestige 7276

Scott LaFaro with Bill Evans

The Village Vanguard Sessions Milestone 47002

Charles Mingus

Changes One Atlantic 1677

Changes Two Atlantic 1678

Ron Carter with Miles Davis

Neils-Henning Ørsted Pedersen with Dexter Gordon

Stable Mable Inner City 2040

Reggie Johnson with Bobby Hutcherson

Total Eclipse Blue Note BST 84291

Bob Cranshaw with Stanley Turrentine

Easy Walker Blue Note BST 84268

Eddie Gomez with Bill Evans

Bill Evans At The Montreux Jazz Festival Verve V-8762

Jymie Merritt with Art Blakey

The Big Beat Blue Note BLP 4029

Moanin' Blue Note BLP 4003